

- RAG Learning

3B.1 The State and Globalisation

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 3B: Global Politics — spec topic 2: Sovereignty and globalisation

Exam Tip: Component 3 has two routes. This is **3B (Global Politics)**; the alternative is **3A (Comparative Politics: USA)**. You sit one, never both. Section B is a compulsory 12-mark question on comparative theories — realism and liberalism — so 3B.6 is unavoidable.

This opens 3B and supplies the framework for everything after it: what a state is, what sovereignty means, and how far globalisation has changed both.

Sovereignty — supreme authority within a territory, free from external control.

Internal sovereignty — supreme authority over everything within the borders.

External sovereignty — independence from outside interference; formal equality with other states.

Nation state — a political community with defined territory, permanent population and sovereign authority.

Non-state actors — NGOs, multinational corporations, armed groups, international organisations.

Globalisation — the growing interconnectedness of societies across borders.

Homogenisation — the tendency of cultures to become more alike.

Interconnectedness — the density of links, so events in one place have effects elsewhere.

Global governance — managing shared problems through rules and institutions without a world government.

World government — a supranational authority with sovereign power over states; does not exist.

Pooled sovereignty — states exercising powers jointly through a shared institution.

1. The state and national sovereignty

The **Westphalian** settlement of 1648 is the conventional origin of sovereign territorial states, formal equality and non-intervention as the cardinal rule. The standard legal criteria of statehood — a permanent population, a defined territory, a government and the capacity to enter relations with other states — come from the **Montevideo Convention (1933)** and remain the working definition.

Feature	Detail
Territorial integrity	Borders are inviolable; this is the principle Russia's actions in Ukraine directly challenged
Monopoly of legitimate force	The defining internal capacity, and what no non-state actor possesses
Legal equality	All states are formally equal in international law regardless of power — one state, one vote in the UN General Assembly
Non-intervention and the prohibition of force	Article 2(4) of the UN Charter (states must not use force against another's territorial integrity or political independence) and Article 2(7) (the UN may not intervene in matters essentially within domestic jurisdiction); qualified in practice by human rights obligations and R2P

Failed and fragile states

A state that can no longer perform basic functions across its territory retains formal external sovereignty while losing effective internal control. The consequences cross borders — conflict, displacement, ungoverned space in which armed groups and organised crime operate — which is why state failure is treated as an international security concern rather than a purely internal matter.

2. Globalisation

Dimension	What it involves	Drivers
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Economic	Trade, foreign investment, capital flows, transnational production networks	Liberalisation, containerisation, the WTO, financial deregulation
Political	International organisations, rules and agreements taking decisions once made by states alone	Post-1945 institution-building; regional integration
Cultural	Flows of ideas, images, media, consumer practices	Communications technology, migration, mass media

Three views of its impact on the state

View	Claim	Evidence cited
Hyperglobalist	Economic integration has eroded state autonomy to the point that the nation state is becoming obsolete	Capital mobility constraining tax and regulatory choices; MNCs larger than many economies
Sceptical	Globalisation is exaggerated; states retain the capacity to regulate, tax and close borders	Pre-1914 integration was comparable; much activity is regional; the pandemic showed borders still work
Transformationalist	Real, but it transforms the state rather than ending it — states became facilitators and regulators, and largely chose integration	States negotiated the trade regime they are said to be captive to

The transformationalist position is now the most widely held, because it accommodates evidence the other two treat selectively.

3. Debates about globalisation's impact

Has it reduced state autonomy?

Yes: capital mobility narrows tax and regulatory choices; treaty obligations bind; transnational problems cross borders; financial markets discipline fiscal policy directly.

But unevenly: large states with deep markets shape the rules others are constrained by.

Globalisation has *redistributed* autonomy as much as reduced it — a point worth making, because it converts a general claim into an analytical one.

Inequality

Globalisation reduced poverty	Globalisation increased inequality
The largest reduction in absolute poverty in history occurred over the same period, principally in China and India	Gains concentrated where capital, skills and institutions already existed; much of sub-Saharan Africa did not converge
Integration gave developing economies access to markets and investment	Within developed states, low-skilled workers faced competition from far cheaper labour — deindustrialisation and regional decline
Technology and knowledge transfer accelerated development	The same capital mobility constrains the taxation that would fund compensation for the losers

Both claims are true, which is why assessments differ so sharply: globalisation reduced *absolute* poverty globally and increased *relative* inequality within many developed states.

Culture

Critics argue cultural globalisation spreads a dominant, largely Western consumer culture that displaces local practice — homogenisation, or "McDonaldisation". The counter-argument is **glocalisation**: global products are adapted locally, and cultural flows run in several directions rather than one.

Does globalisation resolve contemporary issues?

Issue	For	Against
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Conflict	Economic interdependence raises the cost of war between trading partners; no major-power war since 1945	Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022 despite deep energy ties with Europe; interdependence became a weapon (sanctions, gas supply)
Human rights	Norms spread through treaties, NGOs and media; the ICC can prosecute individuals for atrocities	Powerful states and their allies escape enforcement — China over Xinjiang, Myanmar over the Rohingya; trade often trumps rights
Environment	Technology transfer and global agreements (Paris 2015) spread clean energy; solar costs have fallen sharply	Global emissions kept rising with trade and growth; production moves to states with weaker standards — a “race to the bottom”

4. Sovereignty under pressure

Pressure	Effect on sovereignty
International law and human rights	How a state treats its own population became a matter of international concern — breaching the principle that internal conduct is nobody else's business
R2P and humanitarian intervention	Sovereignty reframed as <i>conditional</i> on protecting the population
International criminal law	The ICC prosecutes individuals including heads of state, removing the immunity sovereignty conferred
Pooled sovereignty	States exercise powers jointly — the EU is the developed case; whether this is exercising or surrendering sovereignty is contested
Economic	Treaty obligations, dispute mechanisms, market discipline

The realist objection to conditional sovereignty: enforcement runs through the Security Council, so a P5 interest blocks action regardless of severity. Conditionality is asserted universally and applied selectively — which describes a hierarchy of power rather than a rule of law.

5. Evaluation

Is the nation state obsolete?

No, but transformed. Autonomy over economic policy has narrowed, but states retain the monopoly on force, legal authority and citizenship, and they largely chose integration. The pandemic demonstrated the point under stress: when a genuine crisis arrived, responses were overwhelmingly national — borders closed, vaccines were procured by governments, international coordination was marginal. The return of great power competition has reasserted state centrality further.

Has globalisation undermined democracy?

The most serious version of the charge: decisions with domestic consequence shift to markets and to bodies electorates cannot remove, so the range of choice a national election can deliver narrows. That mismatch — problems operating globally, accountability remaining national — is the strongest structural explanation for the populist backlash of the last decade, and treats it as a response to a real loss of correspondence rather than to a misperception.

Exam Tip: The most useful single analytical move in 3B is the **scale mismatch**: the problems that matter most now operate at a scale where no democratic authority exists, while democratic authority remains national. It works in questions on globalisation, on global governance, on climate and on regionalism — four of the six topics on this route.

Quick recall

- Westphalia 1648: sovereign territorial states, formal equality, non-intervention; statehood criteria from Montevideo 1933
- UN Charter: Art. 2(4) bars states' use of force; Art. 2(7) bars UN intervention in domestic matters

- Internal sovereignty (authority within) / external sovereignty (independence from outside)
- Three dimensions: economic, political, cultural globalisation
- Hyperglobalist / sceptical / transformationalist — the third is now dominant
- Reduced absolute poverty globally; increased relative inequality within developed states
- Sovereignty is now conditional in principle and selectively enforced in practice
- The pandemic showed the state's centrality under stress — responses were national
- The scale mismatch: global problems, national accountability